

To look at a pull-down menu in a Desktop program, just press the title of the menu you want to look at (Figure 5A). The menu will appear and its title (e.g. "Disk") will be highlighted (white letters on a black background). To dismiss the pull-down menu, release the mouse button. If you just want to browse through the available pull-down menus, continue pressing as you move the mouse left and right across the menu bar. Menus will pull down and pop up as you move the pointer across the menu titles.

Selecting an item from the pull-down menus is just as simple. Press the menu title and continue to hold down the mouse button as you drag downward through the items on the menu. As the pointer moves down, the items you point at will be highlighted. Once you've found and selected the menu item you want to use, just release the mouse button. The menu item will flash to signify that your choice has been accepted, and the menu will disappear.

If you decide you don't want to select anything from the menu after all, just move the pointer off the menu entirely and release the mouse button. Or, to select an item from another menu, continue pressing the mouse button and point to one of the other menu titles on the menu bar.

Dimmed Menus & Items

Some menu titles appear dimmed. This indicates that none of the options on the menu are valid actions in the program under the current circumstances. For example, in Figure 5A, the Windows menu is dimmed because no windows are open. Individual items within a menu can also be dimmed—for example, the "Eject" option in the Finder's Disk menu will be dimmed if the disk icon you've selected can't be ejected (if it's a hard drive, for example).

Checked Menu Items

Some menu items have a check mark beside them. For example, the Finder's View menu (Figure 5B) contains a checked item which indicates how the icons in the window are organized. In our example, "by Icon" is checked. If we selected "by Name" from the menu, the window would change to display a list of the icons organized alphabetically by name and the check mark would move to the "by Name" selection. In this case, we can use the menu for two things—to actually change the view of a window, and to see which view a window currently has by looking for the check mark.

The check mark is used in many other programs. For example, word processors have a check mark in their Font menu to tell you which font (type style) you're using, as well as check marks beside each style (bold, underlined, etc.) and size (10 point, 12 point, etc.) in use.

In some cases, the check mark is used in a slightly different way—for example, in a game, there might be a menu item called "Sound." If this item is checked, the game makes noise; if it's not checked, the game is silent. Selecting the "Sound" menu item toggles the check mark—turns it on if it's off, or off if it's on. The context in which the check mark is used will help you determine whether it's used in this way, or in the first way of choosing one choice from a number of possible choices.